was defused. Jairam Ramesh was a good mentor to many of us, since he would generously allow us to shadow him for lessons and the sense of reassurance we derived from it. Since the media department is full of women, this also showed us his genuine support for women's empowerment.

In fact, Jairam Ramesh delegated a lot of work to me. Maharashtra's senior leadership had suggested we hand out flyers in Marathi, explaining the purpose of the Yatra. We were also tasked with the distribution of a thousand special-edition copies of the *National Herald* and *Navjivan* newspapers. We were able to seamlessly accomplish the task with support from the Sewa Dal volunteers Aivaran and Rajendra Prasad (delegated by the Sewa Dal training in-charge Devendra Sharma), as also from Abhijeet Deshmukh and Abhijeet Sapkal, two of Maharashtra Congress's finest lieutenants (who also efficiently delivered on every other request put forth by me).

On other occasions, I was not so lucky. On one admittedly surreal occasion, an official media truck with Telugu branding was travelling in Maharashtra (which in itself was a problem, given our regional sensitivities). But it resulted in even more hilarious consequences when the driver began screaming for the truck to be refuelled in a language none of us understood. So we had to quickly navigate through thousands of yatris to get hold of a Telugu speaker who could act as an impromptu translator!

But the Yatra was also a crash course in managing party organizations. Every organization has some unsavoury elements. I recall some local colleague cribbing about me, yet evading when I attempted to resolve the situation. Similarly, at times, I had to dig out some critical data at the eleventh hour (with no internet and even less help). I also came across misogyny, manipulation, backstabbing, desperation, vanity and intimidation. The interplay of these human complexes and sentiments heightened as the cadence levelled up, inside and outside the organization. But like with life, as with the Congress party. And even though such situations were emotionally stressful for me, I took it in my stride and